

ANI

2.4
MILLION TONNES
India's apple production

>2
LAKH HECTARES
Area under apple cultivation

75
PER CENT
Kashmir's share in total production

ity in summer, we see pests on crops and outbreak of diseases like scabs and insects and mites. It reduces quality and yield." The current high temperature and dryness have resulted in half the fruit falling and the remainder lacking in juice content, he adds.

India produces 2.4 million tonnes of apples annually. The total area under apple cultivation in the country is over 2 lakh hectares, with J&K, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand being the chief apple-producing states. Kashmir produces 75 per cent of the total yield. This year, growers' trade unions and commission agents project a 40 per cent drop. The fruit is also lacking in its trademark red colour, water content and lustre.

Harish Chauhan, convenor of the Hill States Horticulture Forum for Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand, is disheartened to see the farmers sustain mounting losses. In Himachal, after the initial lack of rains resulted in the fall of flowers and buds, floods ravaged another 10 per cent of the orchards. "Whatever was left on the trees was ruined by the floods," says Chauhan, who also serves as the co-convenor of the Sanyukt Kisan Morcha, a conglomerate of 27 farmer outfits. "Similarly, Kashmir, where harvest is under way, will witness a 40 per cent drop in annual output due to diseases, scab and erratic weather. Farmers are suffering losses at both places. We want the government to announce a special package to compensate for flood losses in Himachal, as well as a market intervention scheme (MIS) and crop insurance for growers."

GROWERS FEAR THAT THE FALL IN WASHINGTON APPLE PRICES WILL AFFECT THE PREMIUM QUALITY LOCAL FRUIT

Natural calamities have affected the quality, including the size and colour, of the fruit. The 100 trees in Mushtaq Ahmad's 4-kanal orchard in Nehalpora in north Kashmir would once yield 400 boxes of apples, including the red Delicious and the large and bright red-coloured Maharaji. The unseasonal and incessant rain and the current drought-like spell have resulted in dwarfish and yellow-coloured fruit even as the yield has whittled by half. "I am waiting for divine intervention," says the 52-year-old as he scans the bright afternoon sky for a hint of rain. Walking through a canopy of trees, Ahmad says the rotten and fallen fruit getting crushed underfoot is grade 'C' apple. Apples are classified into A, B and C categories based on size and colour, with 'A' being the premium category. "This year, we have a huge quantity of C-grade apples. We would sell it at throwaway prices, but a large portion of the produce this year is of low quality. Now, I am waiting for rain so that it can give the fruit some colour."

In the wake of floods in Himachal, the Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu-led Congress government in the state had announced that its procurement agencies will pick up the inferior apples at Rs 12 per kg. In Kashmir, the J&K administration had announced an MIS during the two-year lockdown that followed the abrogation of Article 370 in August 2019 and the Covid-19 pandemic lockdown thereafter. It allowed the National Agricultural Cooperative Marketing Federation of India (NAFED) to directly buy apples from growers in Kashmir. Farmers' profits jumped by Rs 2,000 crore. This year, horticulturists in Kashmir rushed to J&K Lieutenant-Governor Manoj Sinha seeking a reintroduction of the same scheme to offset losses from the glut of inferior apples.

On September 13, the Srinagar chapter of the Apple Farmers' Federation of India also submitted a memorandum demanding MIS be restarted. Pointing to the glut of C-grade apples, federation president Zahoor Ahmad Rather says the low-quality fruit will affect market sentiment and spoil the good brand name of the 'Kashmir apple'. "There will be no floor prices, and growers will be forced to sell their stock at throwaway prices. Reduction in the